Steven Denney, Ph.D.

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Short Bio

A political scientist by training, I am Assistant Professor at Leiden University and an affiliated researcher at its Centre for Digital Humanities. I study how political institutions shape and are shaped by national identity, migration, and political behavior using surveys, experiments, and computational text analysis. I also conduct applied policy research on innovation policy, firm growth, and labour markets.

Academic Positions

Current	**Leiden University Institute for Area Studies (LIAS)** Assistant Professor *[Universitair Docent]*
2021–2023	**University of Vienna, Department of East Asian Studies** University Lecturer *[Post-Doc Universitätsassistent*innen]*
2019–2021	**University of Toronto, Munk School of Global Affairs and Public Policy** Postdoctoral Research Fellow

Education

2013–2019	**University of Toronto** Ph.D., Department of Political Science
2011–2013	**Yonsei University** M.A., Global Affairs and Policy
2005–2008	**Harding University** B.A., Department of Political Science

Teaching

Current	**Leiden University** Digital Korea: Introduction to Computational Text Analysis; Digital Humanities; BA Thesis Seminar; International Relations; Regions in World Politics; Methodologies in the Social Sciences and Humanities (MA/PhD); Issues in Korean Studies. University Teaching Qualification (UTQ / BKO), awarded 2026
2021–2023	**University of Vienna** Research Seminar for the Master's and PhD Thesis; Political Systems in East Asia; International Relations in East Asia; Nations and Nationalism in East Asia
2013–2021	**University of Toronto** Methods in Political Science; Political Economy of East Asian Development; Introduction to Comparative Politics

Technical Qualifications

Languages	English (native), Korean (advanced; C2), Spanish (intermediate; B2), German (beginner; B1), Dutch (beginner; A1/2)
Analysis	R, Python, Stata, and NVivo for quantitative and qualitative analysis; OCR and large language models for text extraction and classification
Methods	Survey and experimental design (conjoint, list, framing); computational text analysis; content and discourse analysis; qualitative interviews

Administration & Supervision

Admin	Member, Board of Examiners for Asian Studies, Faculty of Humanities, Leiden University (current); Vice-Director of Study Program, East Asian Economy and Society (EcoS), University of Vienna (2022–2023)
Supervision	BA, MA, and PhD supervision in Korean and East Asian studies, qualitative comparative research, and quantitative social science

Research Grants & Fellowships (USD)

Grants administered as Principal Investigator marked with * and Co-Investigator marked with †

[1] "Textbooks, Nation, and Artificial Intelligence: Reconstructing Korean National Identity." Academy of Korean Studies (AKS), 2026–2028. ($19,262)*

[2] "AI Workforce Intelligence Initiative." Future Skills Centre, via The Dais, Toronto Metropolitan University, 2026. ($33,000)*

[3] "Fairness or Threat? Understanding Sources of Immigration Backlash in Democracies." Dutch Research Council (NWO), SSH - XS 2025, 2025–2026. ($57,000)*

[4] "Integration Challenges and Opportunities in Divided Countries: A Comparative Analysis of Germany and South Korea." IFES-MOU Overseas North Korea-Unification Policy Academic Research Grant, 2023–2024. ($40,000)*

[5] "Who Belongs to the Nation? National Identity and Migrant Integration in South Korea." Academy of Korean Studies (AKS) Research Grant, AKS-2023-R018, 2022–2023. ($13,500)*

[6] "Measuring the Impact of the Digital Economy." Facebook Research Grant, 2021–2023. ($100,000)†

[7] "Neighbors, Employees, and Representatives: Why Do Some North Korean Migrants Integrate and Others Don't?" Academy of Korean Studies (AKS) Research Grant, AKS-2021-R-083, 2020–2021. ($25,000)†

[8] "Information Dissemination in North Korea: The Role of Social Networks, Markets, and Social Change." National Endowment for Democracy (NED) Research Grant, 2020–2021. ($60,000)†

[9] "The Scale-up Challenge? Obstacles to High-Growth Technology-based Firms and the Policy Response." Mitacs–SSHRC Accelerate Grant, Award No. IT10712, 2017–2021. ($150,000)*

[10] "Politics and Process of 'Unification in Action'." UniKorea Fund Grant Program, 2018–2019. ($40,000)*

[11] "Reproducing Contested Korean Identities and Social Structures on the Korean Peninsula." Academy of Korean Studies (AKS) Research Grant, AKS-2015-R49, 2015–2016. ($16,000)†

[12] "Documenting Cultural and Political Information Strategies on the Korean Peninsula, 2012–2013." Academy of Korean Studies (AKS) Research Grant, AKS-2013-R11, 2012–2013. ($15,000)†

[13] Academy of Korean Studies (AKS), Pre-Doctoral Fellowship, 2016. ($9,000)

[14] Richard Simeon Doctoral Student Scholarship, University of Toronto, 2016. ($5,000)

[15] School of Graduate Studies (SGS) Research Grant, University of Toronto, 2016. ($5,000)

[16] Ontario Graduate Scholarship (OGS) Visa Award, University of Toronto, 2014. ($25,000)

Research & Publications

Peer-Reviewed Articles

[1] Denney, S., Steinhardt, H. Christoph, & Bhowmick, L. (2026). Identity conformity in Taiwan and South Korea: Why citizens in divided societies are pressured to overstate national pride. *Nationalism and Ethnic Politics*. doi:10.1080/13537113.2026.2616954

[2] Brehm, R., Zhou, T., & Denney, S. (2025). From division to democracy: Integration of post-communist citizens in Germany and South Korea. *Communist and Post-Communist Studies*. doi:10.1525/cpcs.2025.2636997

[3] Denney, S., Ward, P., & Green, C. (2025). Public support for migrant entrepreneurship: The case of North Koreans in the Republic of Korea. *International Migration Review*, 59(3), 1156–1180. doi:10.1177/01979183231203927

[4] Ward, P., & Denney, S. (2025). Welfare chauvinism in divided societies: The role of national identity in social policy preferences. *Policy and Society*. doi:10.1093/polsoc/puaf027

[5] Ward, P., & Denney, S. (2025). Partisan voters in party systems with ephemeral parties: Evidence from South Korea. *Party Politics*. doi:10.1177/13540688251339976

[6] Ward, P., Denney, S., & Green, C. (2024). 한국인의통일방식에대한숨겨진선호: 선택형컨조인트분석 (Choice-based Conjoint Analysis) 결과를중심으로 [Hidden preferences of South Koreans on the method of unification: Results from a choice-based conjoint analysis]. *국가전략* [National Strategy], 30(1), 137–163. doi:10.35390/sejong.30.1.202402.006

[7] Green, C., & Denney, S. (2024). Why do democratic societies tolerate undemocratic laws? Sorting public support for the National Security Act in South Korea. *Democratization*, 31(1), 113–131. doi:10.1080/13510347.2023.2258082

[8] Denney, S., & Green, C. (2024). Public attitudes towards co-ethnic migrant integration: Evidence from South Korea. *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*, 50(8), 1998–2022. doi:10.1080/1369183X.2023.2286207

[9] Ward, P., & Denney, S. C. (2023). How autocracies disrupt unsanctioned information flows: The role of state power and social capital in North Korea. *Problems of Post-Communism*, 71(2), 177–191. doi:10.1080/10758216.2023.2180038

[10] Denney, S., Breznitz, S., & Zhang, Q. (2023). Too much support? Entrepreneurial ecosystems and firm growth. *The Journal of Technology Transfer*, 49(3), 996–1015. doi:10.1007/s10961-023-10013-1

[11] Denney, S., Wolfe, D. A., & Southin, T. (2023). Do winners pick government? How scale-up experience shapes entrepreneurs' assessments of innovation policy mixes. *Science and Public Policy*, 50(5), 858–870. doi:10.1093/scipol/scad030

[12] Ward, P., & Denney, S. (2022). Welfare chauvinism among co-ethnics: Evidence from a conjoint experiment in South Korea. *International Migration*, 60(5), 74–90. doi:10.1111/imig.12937

[13] Wolfe, D. A., DiFrancesco, R. J., & Denney, S. C. (2022). Localization of global networks: New mandates for MNEs in Toronto's innovation economy. *Cambridge Journal of Regions, Economy and Society*, 15(2), 323–342. doi:10.1093/cjres/rsac002

[14] Denney, S., Ward, P., & Green, C. (2022). The limits of ethnic capital: Impacts of social desirability on Korean views of co-ethnic immigration. *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*, 48(7), 1669–1689. doi:10.1080/1369183X.2020.1797477

[15] Denney, S., & Green, C. (2021). Who should be admitted? Conjoint analysis of South Korean attitudes toward immigrants. *Ethnicities*, 21(1), 120–145. doi:10.1177/1468796820916609

[16] Denney, S., & Green, C. (2021). North Korean patriotism: Assessing the success and failures of a nation. *Korea Journal*, 61(1), 154–185. doi:10.25024/kj.2021.61.1.154

[17] Denney, S., Southin, T., & Wolfe, D. A. (2021). Entrepreneurs and cluster evolution: The transformation of Toronto's ICT cluster. *Regional Studies*, 55(2), 196–207. doi:10.1080/00343404.2020.1762854

[18] Song, J., & Denney, S. C. (2019). Studying North Korea through North Korean migrants: Lessons from the field. *Critical Asian Studies*, 51(3), 451–466. doi:10.1080/14672715.2019.1611462

[19] Cathcart, A., Green, C., & Denney, S. C. (2014). How authoritarian regimes maintain domain consensus: North Korea's information strategies in the Kim Jong-un era. *The Review of Korean Studies*, 17(2), 145–178. doi:10.25024/review.2014.17.2.005

[20] Denney, S. C., & Green, C. K. (2013). Towards a developmental understanding of North Korea: An institutional approach to economic reform and development. *European Journal of Korean Studies*, 15, 92–111.

[21] Cathcart, A., & Denney, S. C. (2013). North Korea's cultural diplomacy in the early Kim Jong-un era. *North Korean Review*, 9(2), 29–42. doi:10.3172/NKR.9.2.29

Papers Under Review

[1] Denney, S., Kelly, R., & Wolfe, D. A. (2026). Scaling for success? Coverage, timing, and the reach of Canadian federal innovation support. R&R at *Canadian Public Policy*. github.com/scdenney/bigs-scaleups

[2] Denney, S., Fraser, N., & Steinhardt, H. C. (2026). Cues of commitment: Integration and naturalization support in Taiwan and South Korea. R&R at *British Journal of Political Science*. github.com/scdenney/cues-east-asia

[3] Denney, S., van Dam, I., & Green, C. (2026). Persuasion and prejudice: Are South Korean attitudes toward immigration open to change? R&R at *International Migration*. github.com/scdenney/persuasion-cues-kr-imm

[4] Denney, S., & Steinhardt, H. C. (2026). Measuring national identity with conjoint experiments using the case of Taiwan. Under review at *Political Behavior*. ssrn.com/abstract=7027118

[5] Denney, S. (2026). Governing immigration by the rules: Legal procedure, equal treatment, and public support across four countries. Under review at *American Political Science Review*. ssrn.com/abstract=7564458; Preregistration

[6] Denney, S., & DiGiuseppe, M. (2026). JEV versus LLMs: Accuracy, cost and calibration on seven political science replications. Under review at *Journal of Computational Social Science*. arxiv.org/abs/2610.06625

Papers in Progress

[1] Denney, S. (2026). Democracy and nationalism, reconsidered. ssrn.com/abstract=6904542

[2] Denney, S., & van de Pol, A. (2026). Constructing the nation: Identity and historical narratives in South Korean history textbooks. ssrn.com/abstract=6966183

[3] Denney, S., & Steinhardt, H. C. (n.d.). Political regimes and the shape of nationalism: A conjoint approach to the content of national identity in Mainland China and Taiwan. Pre-registration

[4] Denney, S., & Trummel, T. (n.d.). Civic fairness and the evaluation of individual immigrants. Pre-registration

[5] Denney, S. (n.d.). A survey experiment on creedal nationalist persuasion. Pre-registration

[6] Steinhardt, H. C., & Denney, S. (n.d.). Rules, not race? What AfD voters want from migration policy.

[7] Denney, S., & Lee, B. (n.d.). Measuring political bias in South Korean history textbooks.

[8] Denney, S., & Lee, M. (n.d.). Authoritarian education and post-transition citizens: Evidence from South Korea and Poland.

[9] Denney, S., & Ward, P. (n.d.). No previews in Pyongyang: Reform discourse and policy change in North Korea, 1987–2020.

[10] Denney, S., Breuker, R., & van de Pol, A. (n.d.). Sorting the socialist capital: A residential geography of Pyongyang from the household registry.

[11] Vu, V., & Denney, S. (2026). Are we there yet? A measurement framework for how AI impacts work and the economy.

[12] Vu, V., Denney, S., Shahidi, F. V., & Jain, S. (2026). Adoption without disruption? Generative AI and the changing Canadian labour market.

Theses

[1] Denney, S. C. (2019). *Does democracy matter? Political change and national identification in South Korea and beyond* (Ph.D. dissertation, Department of Political Science, University of Toronto).

[2] Denney, S. C. (2013). *Nation, state, and national economy: The early 19th century American developmental state* (M.A. thesis, Graduate School of Yonsei University).

Books

[1] Denney, S. C. (n.d.). *Nationalism under democracy: Why institutions matter for national identity and belonging* [manuscript being revised].

[2] Denney, S. C., & Lee, M. (n.d.). *Democracy at school: Authoritarian education, post-transition citizens, and the long shadow of the Cold War in South Korea and Poland* [manuscript in preparation].

[3] Cathcart, A., Green, C., & Denney, S. C. (Eds.). (2020). *Decoding the Sino–North Korean borderlands*. Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press.

Book Chapters

[1] Denney, S. C. (2024). Plus ça change? South Korean public opinion of the United States during the Trump administration. In M. Lerner & D. Fields (Eds.), *Divided America, divided Korea*. Cambridge University Press.

[2] Denney, S. C. (2019). Democratic support and generational change in South Korea. In G. A. Brazinsky (Ed.), *Korea and the world: New frontiers in Korean studies*. Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield.

[3] Denney, S. C., Green, C., & Cathcart, A. (2016). Kim Jong-un and the practice of Songun politics. In A. Cathcart et al. (Eds.), *Change and continuity in North Korean politics*. Routledge.

[4] Denney, S. C., & Green, C. (2016). Pockets of efficiency: An institutional approach to economic reform and development. In A. Cathcart et al. (Eds.), *Change and continuity in North Korean politics*. Routledge.

[5] Hayes, P., Denney, S. C., et al. (2015). The implications of civic diplomacy for ROK foreign policy. In P. Hayes & K. Yi (Eds.), *Complexity, security and civil society in East Asia: Foreign policies and the Korean Peninsula*. Open Book Publishers.

Reports & Applied Research

[1] Denney, S. C., & Ward, P. (2023). Information dissemination in North Korea: A report for NGOs. National Endowment for Democracy (NED), January.

[2] Denney, S. C., Vu, V., & Kelly, R. (2021). Into the scale-up-verse: Exploring the landscape of Canada's high performing firms. IPL & Brookfield Institute, December.

[3] Denney, S. C., & Vu, V. (2021). Just out of reach: The elusive quest to measure the digital economy. Brookfield Institute, June.

[4] Denney, S. C., & Vu, V. (2021). Scale the gap: The impact of growth barriers on women entrepreneurs in Canadian high-growth firms. Brookfield Institute, April.

[5] Denney, S. C., Ward, P., & Abrahamian, A. (2020). North Korean refugee entrepreneurs in South Korea: Unveiling Korea's hidden potential. The Asia Foundation, December.

[6] Denney, S. C. (2020). Political order and civic space in the Asia Pacific: A multilevel analysis of trends, 1989–2020. UNICEF Office of Global Insight and Policy.

[7] Denney, S. C. (2020). Impact of COVID-19 on the market research community. Delvinia–Insights Association Special Report, May.

[8] Denney, S. C., Green, C., & Ward, P. (2019). New values & old orders: Where do North Koreans fit in the new South Korea? Leiden Asia Centre, May.

[9] Denney, S. C., & Green, C. (2018). Unification in action? The national identity of North Korean defector-migrants: Insights and implications. Korean Economic Institute of America: Academic Paper Series, October.

[10] Denney, S. C., Green, C., & Gleason, B. (2015). The whisper in the ear: Re-defector press conference as information management tool. KEI Academic Paper Series, March.

Selected Policy Papers & Commentary

[1] Denney, S. C., & Green, C. (2023). Because it is good for South Korea: Public support for defector entrepreneurship. *38 North*, January.

[2] Denney, S. C. (2022). Human rights and the future of the international order: Where does Seoul stand? *Korea On Point*, November.

[3] Denney, S. C., & Green, C. (2022). Improving North Korean defector integration in South Korea: Survey findings and recommendations. *38 North*, May.

[4] Denney, S. C. (2022). South Koreans support immigration, but conditions apply. Italian Institute for International Political Studies (ISPI), March.

[5] Denney, S. C., & Vu, V. (2021). Great Canadian Survey of 2021: Insights for the Council of Canadian Innovators. IPL & Brookfield Institute, July.

[6] Denney, S. C., & Vu, V. (2019). The COVID-19 crisis and policy preferences of Canadian technology scale-ups. IPL Research Report 2020-02, March.

[7] Denney, S. C. (2016). Identité nationale et nationalisme nord-coréens [North Korean national identity and nationalism]. *Korea Analysis*, 11, 40–44.

[8] Denney, S. C. (2016). «Hell Chosun», expression de l'insatisfaction de la jeunesse sud-coréenne ["Hell Chosun:" Expressions of dissatisfaction among South Korean youth]. *Korea Analysis*, 9, 42–45.

Selected Reviews

[1] Denney, S. (2026). Review of *Welfare Nationalism in Europe and Russia: The Politics of 21st Century Exclusionary and Inclusionary Migrations*, by Linda J. Cook. *Perspectives on Politics*.

[2] Denney, S. (2026). Review of *Narratives of Civic Duty: How National Stories Shape Democracy in Asia*, by Aram Hur. *Korean Histories*, 5(1), 86–87.

[3] Denney, S. (2026). Review of *North Korea's Mundane Revolution: Socialist Living and the Rise of Kim Il-sung, 1953–1965*, by Andre Schmid. *Korean Histories*, 5(1), 83–84.

[4] Denney, S. (2024). Review of *From development to democracy: The transformations of modern Asia*, by Dan Slater and Joseph Wong. *Pacific Affairs*, 97(4).

[5] Denney, S. (2022). Review of *After the Korean War: An intimate history*, by Heonik Kwon. *Pacific Affairs*, 95(1).

[6] Denney, S. (2018). Review of *Park Chung Hee and modern Korea: The roots of militarism, 1866–1945*, by Carter Eckert. *Korea Journal*, 58(3), 184–190.

[7] Denney, S. (2018). Review of *Unveiling the North Korean economy: Collapse and transition*, by Byung-Yeon Kim. *Journal of American–East Asian Relations*, 25(1), 93–96.

[8] Denney, S. (2018). Review of *North Korea's hidden revolution*, by Jieun Baek. *Pacific Affairs*, 91(1), 176–178.

[9] Denney, S. (2014). Review of *The Oxford handbook of the international relations of Asia*. *The Asan Forum*, 2(6).

[10] Denney, S. (2012). To never forget, one must first know [Review of *Escape from Camp 14*, by Blaine Harden]. *Korea Review*, 2(2), 171–175.

Selected Conferences, Workshops & Presentations

2023–2026 only

[1] "Political Regimes and the Shape of Nationalism," American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting, Boston, September 6, 2026.

[2] "Governing Immigration by the Rules: Legal Procedure, Equal Treatment, and Public Support Across Four Countries," American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting, Boston, September 4, 2026.

[3] "No Previews in Pyongyang: Reform Discourse and Policy Change in North Korea, 1987–2020," European Centre for North Korean Studies (ECNK) Webinar, University of Vienna, August 4, 2026.

[4] "Identity Conformity in Taiwan and South Korea: Why Citizens in Divided Societies Are Pressured to Overstate National Pride," Korea University, May 13, 2026.

[5] "Constructing the Nation: Identity and Historical Narratives in South Korean History Textbooks," Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA) Conference, April 2026.

[6] "Fairness, Threat, and the Norms-Based Model of Immigration Legitimacy," Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA) Conference, April 2026.

[7] "What Were They Thinking?" Using Open-Text Responses to Validate Constructs in Conjoint Survey Experiments, Leiden University Centre for Digital Humanities (LUCDH) Lunch Lecture Series, Leiden University, March 24, 2026.

[8] "Guardianship Democracy: Mapping Elite Rule Preferences in East and Southeast Asia," 8th Annual Meeting of the Social Science Korean Studies Network in Europe (SoKEN), University of Duisburg–Essen, May 23–24, 2025.

[9] "Persuasion and Prejudice: Are South Korean Attitudes toward Immigration Open to Change?," Recalibrating 'Skill' in Changing Immigration Regimes, Asia Research Institute, National University of Singapore, January 16–17, 2025.

[10] "Democracy and Nationalism: The Case of Taiwan," American Political Science Association (APSA) Conference, September 4–8, 2024.

[11] "Determinants of Foreign Information Use in North Korea: Research Findings and Implications," International North Korean Studies Networking Forum, Yonsei University, August 5, 2024.

[12] "Who Are 'We' and How Do We Know It? New Experimental Designs for Measuring National Identity," Consequences of Identity Politics Workshop, University of Southampton, July 24–25, 2024.

[13] "How Inclusive Are National Identities in East Asian Democracies? Exploring a New Conjoint Approach," East Asia Institute, National University of Singapore, July 19, 2024.

[14] "Public Attitudes Towards Immigrant Incorporation in South Korea, Taiwan, and Japan," European Political Science Association (EPSA) Conference, July 4–6, 2024.

[15] "Plus ça change? South Korean Public Opinion of the United States During the Trump Administration," International Korean Studies Institute (IKSU) Summer School, June 19, 2024.

[16] "Public Support for Citizenship Expansion in East Asian Democracies," LIAS Talk Series, Leiden Institute for Asian Studies, May 15, 2024.

[17] "The Enduring Legacy of Forced Division: Welfare Nationalism in Germany and South Korea," Korean Studies Research Seminar, LIAS, Leiden University, April 17, 2024.

[18] "Size or Speed? Public Attitudes toward Rising Immigration Levels in Historically Homogeneous Nations," American Political Science Association (APSA) Conference, August 31–September 3, 2023.

[19] "Measuring National Identity: A Choice-Based Conjoint Approach," Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA) Conference, April 13–16, 2023.

[20] "Why Do Democratic Societies Tolerate Undemocratic Laws? Sorting Public Support for the National Security Act in South Korea," International Studies Association (ISA) Conference, March 15–18, 2023.

[21] "Nationalism Under Democracy: Why Institutions Matter for National Identity and Belonging," Ostasienforum, Department of East Asian Studies, University of Vienna, May 24, 2023.

Academic Service & Affiliations

Open source	Open educational resources for computational text analysis and quantitative research methods, including curated datasets, instructional materials, and corpora for Korean studies
Affiliations	Director of Research, SinoNK.com (current); Non-Resident Fellow, Innovation Policy Lab, University of Toronto (2019–present); Senior Fellow, European Centre for North Korean Studies, University of Vienna (2022–present); Affiliated Researcher, Leiden University Centre for Digital Humanities (LUCDH), Leiden University (2026–present)
Reviewer	Government and Opposition, Democratization, International Political Science Review, International Migration, Asian Studies Review, Social Science Journal, Regional Studies, Communist and Post-Communist Studies, Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies
Member	International Studies Association, Association for Asian Studies, Midwest Political Science Association, American Political Science Association, European Consortium for Political Research

Other Professional Experience

2019–Present	Collaborator, The Dais (formerly Brookfield Institute for Innovation + Entrepreneurship)
2020–2021	Research Analyst & Consultant, United Nations
2019–2021	Deemed Employee, Statistics Canada
2018–2019	Research Analyst & Consultant, E&Y / Toronto Global
2018–2019	Research Analyst & Consultant, Asia Foundation
2014–2017	Contributor & Analyst, The Diplomat